The Lighthouse on Dry Land

Tier	Tier 2
Party Level	**5 PCs at L6** — Nalith (Piper), Naan (Lilli), Kto (Kaitlyn), Yinu (Sev), **Juniper's character** (name/build open; the DM never builds a player's character). Size to **5×L6**: Easy 1,500 · Medium 3,000 · Hard 4,500 · Deadly 7,000
Duration	~2 hours
Setting	**Impiltur**, former bed of the Sea of Fallen Stars — the **Salt Way**, the dry seabed (**the Drywater**), the **Sarshel Light**. Canon: *Forgotten Realms Campaign Guide* **p. 0145**
Hook From	**End of Session 006** — thrown out of the Bright Court Beneath, the party lands on the Salt Way at the **west edge of a trap with a one-mile radius already closed across the road**



Adventure Summary

Session 006 ended mid-air: Sela Wyndmere cut Oberon's ribbon and the seam threw the party out with no say in where they would land. They land on the **Salt Way**, a dead shoreline road in western Impiltur, on the floor of a sea that left decades ago — **no questgiver, no contract, no road home**, Shadowdale unreachable behind them and its drow clock running without them.

Inside the first mile they are caught in the **lighthouse snare** †: the Sarshel Light's old Impilturan light-ward — built to burn demons back off a shoreline — **reversed by the Fraternity of Tharos**. It no longer wards; it *lures*: fleeing along the road bends you back to the same **broken milestone**, and the sky overhead never moves. **Two things run on one anchor** — the **snare** (the ward reversed at the *lamp*) and **the Drawing** † (the rite at the *top of the tower*: three fire-scribed pedestals, four bound innocents, and the seal's lesser **emissary**, drawn up through the lens to crack the **Sarshel Seal** in the seabed rock). **Tonight is the final window; the last phase is scheduled for true dawn, about three hours after the party lands.**

Orin Vale has kept ten travellers alive in the wreck of the *Amber Gull* — nine lured, and himself — for six weeks, and buried two. **Four of his people are bound to brackets in the lantern room**, taken three nights ago. **Tamsin Reed**, the keeper, has served inside the lamp's thrall for **three months**: not a cultist but the first victim, and the best witness to how the lamp can be repaired.

Three wins, three different costs. Smash the lens — fast: conduit broken, emissary dragged back into the seal, snare dead for everyone in the mile, **and the old ward dies with it**, leaving the seal **unwarded**. **Restore the alignment** — three arms worked by hand mid-fight: conduit resealed, emissary **banished**, **refuge preserved**, drained captives wake (subject to the three-round post-breach recovery limit). **Shutter the lamp** — one action with the keeper's key and code: the snare ends for everyone and **the Drawing runs on**. Then dawn, and nine miles east to **New Sarshel**.

> ***DM — what this is not.*** *No return to Shadowdale, no contract.* ***Sela's fate stays unresolved****, with Yinu's compromised cipher book, Naan's undisclosed Lathander letter, Oberon's disposition, and the Vhaeraunian clock (Threads Left Open).* ***The cult did not cause the portal, summon the party, or know they were falling*** *— say it plainly and let the table check it.*

The Night's Shape — three phases, one deadline

Geography. The snare is a **1-mile-radius shell centred on the lamp**. The party lands at its **west edge**, on the road by the broken milestone — **one mile west of the tower**; the camp sits **midway** (~½ mile from each) 400 ft off the road seaward, the turning beam in plain view; the tower is the centre of the two-mile-wide region; **New Sarshel is nine miles east of the tower, outside the shell.**

Phase	What it is	Clock
1 — The Lure (Act I)	The mile holds the road: loop, visions, the camp of the caught.	**No combat clock**; the night deadline runs
2 — The Approach (2.1)	The dry seabed, the tower, the keeper in the road. Optional, non-lethal, skippable.	No combat clock; deadline runs
3 — The Breach (2.2)	Lantern room: interrupt Veyra or reach the scheduled rite at dawn	Six-segment clock begins at dawn or when confronted; see authoritative Clock start below

Deadline: true dawn is three hours after landing. The fixed sky is an optical illusion; time continues. Orin’s hourglass and the dated ritual schedule reveal the deadline without a check; near dawn the false sky flickers. Use travel and player choices, not table discussion time, to track elapsed hours. The cult has spent three months corrupting the ward; three

nights ago it gathered its final captives. Tonight the prepared charge will break the seal. Confrontation can force Veyra to spend that charge early; her panic creates an opportunity to interfere.

Pace	Reaching the lantern room	What the DM runs
Arrive with over one hour until dawn	Preparations unfinished	Third pedestal unlit (counts as inactive); emissary arrives round 2. Veyra is surprised only if the normal stealth/surprise rules justify it
One short rest	Costs one hour, not an automatic encounter penalty	Use actual time remaining: early if still over one hour; otherwise normal setup. Resting does not independently alter the encounter
Within the final hour before dawn	All preparations ready	Normal setup. Veyra starts the clock if confronted; otherwise waits until dawn
Long rest (8 hrs)	After dawn	The Drawing **completes while they sleep** — play **Too Late**; announce it before the rest starts

> ***A clock, not a whip.*** *Skipping the camp's rest is never the wrong call — it buys a* ***stated advantage*** *at the tower. Only the world's clock prices a longer rest; never retro-fit a penalty onto a rest already taken.*

The Snare — Rules and Exits

† The reversed light-ward covers a **one-mile-radius sphere centred on the lamp**. Only the road loops; stepping off it escapes the loop, **not** the visions or false sky. Cross the physical sphere to end every local effect. A direct route from its centre to the rim takes about 20 minutes at normal walking speed, longer in rough ground. From the west-edge landing, a short off-road walk west is enough. The camp is still inside the sphere. No invisible barrier prevents leaving.

- **Loop:** travelling on the road away from the lamp folds back to the broken milestone; an attempted departure demonstrates this within five minutes. Toward the tower never loops. Off-road travel follows ordinary geography. Visions persist inside the radius but never compel movement.
- **Visions (a lure, never a leash).** Hourly on the road a creature sees its own **longing** as real. **It never dictates a PC's behaviour:** ask what the character wants most, show it, let them take **one step**, hand control back. **WIS DC 13** (or *detect magic*, or comparing notes) = **disbelieving**.
- **Rest:** time and sleep work normally. The camp offers shelter, food, and company; a long rest is possible elsewhere too, but eight hours misses the announced dawn deadline. The nail suppresses local illusions within 10 ft; it is not the only place sleep is possible.

Exit	How	Caveat
A. Step off the road	Avoid the looping route; navigate normally toward the actual boundary	Visions remain until the boundary, without forcing behavior
B. Suppress it (magic)	† *Dispel magic*: treat the personal glamour as a 3rd-level magical effect, ended automatically on one creature; the anchor can reapply it on entering its beam again. *Remove curse*: ends the personal mark until next dawn. *Detect magic*: senses nearby magic under its normal range/visibility rules; it does not map the sphere. *Daylight*: illumination, not an automatic dispel	Homebrew effects stated explicitly; spells keep their normal casting time, targeting, and concentration
C. Cross the boundary	Walk off-road, or use available flight/teleportation with its normal limits to cross the sphere	*Fly* is a 3rd-level spell potentially available at Level 6; check actual sheets. No invented 200-ft height or 300-ft jump escape threshold
D. Follow the light	Camp about 15 minutes from landing; tower about 30 minutes total on foot	Camp can be approached or bypassed; choices remain open
E. Put the light out	Shutter it (key + code, 1 action) or **smash the lens** (2.2) — the snare ends for everyone in the mile	Shuttering leaves the Drawing running; smashing costs the ward

> ***Hand the rules over fast.*** *Once anyone sees the road is the lie, say so plainly — players who don't know a trap's rules can't out-think it.*

Act I — The Wrong Road

~50 minutes. The cold open, the trap, and the people it already ate.

Act I, Scene 1.1 — The Broken Milestone

Purpose / transition: Cold-open the instant S6 cut; establish the snare, the geography, the deadline, and the fifth traveller inside 20 minutes.

Setting

- **Location:** the **Salt Way**, an old Impilturan shoreline road across the former seabed (canon, CG p. 0145) — cracked blue-grey silt, salt-bleached pine, oyster middens, a leaning mile-stone. The **west edge of the snare, one mile west of the tower.**
- **See:** A night that is not moving — fixed moon, stars pinned, salt-fog to 120 ft — and a road unspooling both ways. **One yellow-white light turns low to the east: a lighthouse with no water to warn.** At their feet, the **broken milestone**, coral-crusted, its numeral chipped to a stub — and the chip looks fresh.
- **Hear:** No surf; the sea is miles behind. Wind scraping salt, old hulls creaking on dry ground, and **a bell-buoy tolling where no water has been for decades** — plus the same gull crying the same three notes each time the road comes back around.
- **Smell:** Dry brine, salt-dust, baked oyster shell, cold ash. **Nothing green, nothing rotting** — the air is preserved, which is the tell.
- **Sense:** *(gated)* **Detect magic** — one vast shell of abjuration under an illusion school; old, Impilturan, running **backwards**. **Divine Sense** — *desecrated consecration*: a holy ward inverted. **Passive Perception 14+** — the chip is newer each return. **Arcana DC 13** — a sea-king light-ward keyed to a seabed seal. **Insight DC 12** — the calm is manufactured; these people are *held*.

NPCs: None. **Encounter:** None.

The landing

The PCs at this table come down hard — **no damage, no lost gear, no Sela.** Play the difference: dark, flat, silent; no wood, no court, no dale. Anyone checking the stone, the flats, or the road signs can place themselves (History or Survival DC 12, or the carved letters **SAR—EL**): **Impiltur, the coast road west of New Sarshel, on ground that was underwater.**

> ***Attendance:*** *Nalith, Naan, Kto, and Yinu arrive from the portal. Juniper's character witnesses them from the road and joins immediately; name, build, background, and resources follow the player's sheet. Tyvlex was present in Session 006 but is off-camera this session; her location remains a DM/player decision. Do not invent a death, capture, or separation crisis for absent PCs.*

Juniper's character — the fifth traveller *(any name, class, or build)*

Juniper's character is **already on the road and witnesses the four returning PCs land**. Offer a traveling reason only if the player wants one; leave background, resources, and prior knowledge to the player. Comparing incompatible visions is their first shared discovery. No exhaustion, damage, or resource refresh is imposed. The five-player party is together from the opening minute.

The wander, the loop, the vision

Let them compare their visions immediately; each player chooses what their character sees and how to respond. An initial moment of disorientation is description, not forced action. The camp gives an answering lantern signal through the fog; Orin calls that four people were taken to the tower. If the party tests the road away from the lamp, the milestone returns within five minutes. Off-road movement avoids that loop; visions persist until the true boundary. No skill roll is needed to share these clues.

Conditional follow-through:

Toward the light: camp in ~15 minutes, tower ~30 minutes from landing. Scene 1.2 is an offered stop, not mandatory; if bypassed, the names of the missing reach them in Orin's warning and the restoration clues remain at the tower.

Off-road: ordinary movement; the camp's answering lantern remains an option. Walking west over the actual boundary ends local effects. Do not redirect that choice to the camp.

Out of the mile (C): let it stand. Play **Walk Away** — road east open, the camp's people still caught, the four bound when the window opens. State the cost once, then play it. **Never body-block them back onto the road.**

Otherwise: the loop returns them to the milestone, the visions sharpen, the cook-fire in the *Amber Gull*'s ribs shows seaward. → **Scene 1.2.**

Act I, Scene 1.2 — The Stranded Camp

Purpose / transition: A place, a face, and a valve — and the whole plot (timeline, tally, keeper, the missing four) handed over **without a mandatory skill check**, with the missing known **before** the party chooses to go up.

Setting

- **Location:** the ribcage of the ***Amber Gull***, a Telflamm trader left high and dry when the sea went out sixty years ago — **400 ft off the Salt Way, midway between landing and tower**: hull for wall and roof, tarps to the masts, a cook-fire of scrap iron, **a row of salt-stained boots nailed along the rail — one pair per traveller still living.**
- **See:** Hides against the wind; a tally of the missing cut into the rail; a bent **iron nail** on a leather cord by the fire, the salt-fog visibly *not* touching it — the one dry, quiet patch in the mile. **Ten living people:** Orin at the fire with his tally-book and a boot on his knee, **eight** asleep or staring, **Ilde Marsh** sitting apart facing the light. From the fire the beam sweeps low over the flat.
- **Hear:** Low voices that stop when the party arrives; someone counting under their breath without noticing; the fire's hiss, hull copper flexing, that bell-buoy.
- **Smell:** Woodsmoke, old tar, wet wool, weak tea, salt crust — and under it, faint but real, **rendered tallow and burnt hair**, which the camp has stopped noticing and the party should not.
- **Sense:** *(gated)* **Detect magic** — the nail carries one live thread of the *old* light-ward: within 10 ft the glamour goes quiet. **Divine Sense** — the ground is desecrated in a long patient line running at the tower. **Arcana/Religion DC 13** (or a plain look at the ledger page) — demon-naming fire-script, the Fraternity's induction rite writ small. **Insight DC 12** — not addled; *hopeful*, which is worse.

NPCs: Orin Vale; Ilde Marsh; the eight other lured; and — by name — the four the tower took.

Orin Vale — the man who kept them alive †

Visual — show the handout when they first see them, and read these cues aloud:

Wiry, weather-beaten, grey stubble — and unhurried: he finishes a boot-stitch before he looks up.

A rope-belt with a **bent iron nail** hanging off it, on a leather cord.

Keeps the camp fed and counted, and keeps his own tally-book close.

Wants the light **out**, does not care how, and will show you what he has written down.

Disposition going in: wary for ten seconds, then instantly useful. Six weeks at this camp; **two people buried**; strangers who walked in *without* walking to the light are the first good news he has had.

Personality (play him warm): practical, unhurried, task-first. He mends boots while he talks and hands out tea in a fixed order, **counting the cups**, a habit he never explains and never stops. He says little of himself, remembers everything about everyone else, is **ashamed** of the two who died before he understood the road, wants his four back and the light **out** any way, and is quietly **afraid** of what is wearing his friend's coat.

History: a supply courier who knows the old coast road; Tamsin is his friend. Six weeks ago she gave him a ward-nail, a dated warning, and a copied maintenance page during a lucid interval. Her original log stays in the tower. Since the four were taken three nights ago, he has tried twice to reach them; Tamsin drove him back at the door. Andry escaped briefly from the tower during a transfer, brought out the torn ledger schedule, then was recaptured while guiding the other prisoners. Orin keeps that fragment with his tally.

Count: fifteen other travelers arrived over six weeks: nine now at camp (Ilde plus eight), four captive upstairs, two died of exposure during early attempts to leave. Orin makes ten living people at camp. They know off-road travel is possible but most stayed hoping for missing kin; Orin stayed to rescue his friends. Offer evacuation plainly: they are vulnerable and reluctant, not magically unable to step outside.

Evidence, no roll: Tamsin’s dated warning identifies the reversal and asks Orin to protect travelers. The copied maintenance page shows the three alignment arms, watch-words, and shutter mechanism. His tally accounts for the fifteen travelers. Andry’s ledger fragment names the four captives and tonight’s dawn deadline; it does not reveal every New Sarshel contact. Only Veyra’s complete ledger can supply those addresses.

Possible outcomes and effects: shelter offered (the warded berth — see *Rest & Recovery*). **Alienated:** he prioritizes evacuation rather than assisting at the tower; residents still make their own choices.

Ilde Marsh — the one still walking toward it †

- **Disposition:** friendly, unbothered, unarguable. **Capable, calm, immovable** — the camp's **organizer** (water, food, fire, boots, the whole order of the place) and the reason it has not fallen apart. Likes Orin; thinks he has given up.
- **Motivations:** her drowned son stands in the lamp-room door, dry and grown. Turned back **nine times — never by the loop**, which has never caught her walking *that* way, but by **the keeper driving her off the tideline** and by **the vision fading** as the lamp turned and the doorway came up empty.
- **Choices:** Ilde can accept conflicting-vision evidence without a mandatory check, organize evacuation, or follow the party seeking closure. If she approaches Veyra, allow warnings and interception. Seizing her requires a successful ordinary grapple; binding her requires another action on a later turn while still grappled. Neither action advances the clock. She is never teleported upstairs or automatically added as a penalty.

The eight others †

Scared, courteous, patient in a way that reads as hopelessness. **The differing visions:** ask three, get three unrelated things (a wife lost in the Tasseldale, a boat never wrecked, a purse of gold, a roofed house, a daughter's wedding) — **nobody sees the same thing and everybody sees the same light.** Hand it over free: it makes the party smarter than the snare and turns Ilde. Anyone freed goes quiet a while, grieving the vision.

The four the tower took — Orin's people †

Name them at this table, with their faces — they were campers here for weeks, so the party meets their stories before the brackets and the rescue is a rescue, not a tally.

- **Halen Croy** — a bargeman's boy, twelve. Counts things to steady himself: the boots on the rail, the gull's calls, the days. Orin taught him knots; he was quick and proud of it.
- **Merra Voss** — a pedlar who worked the Salt Way for years before the road closed. Knows every traveller's name in camp; kept its accounts on a slate until the night she walked at the light.
- **Bett Ralen** — a fisher's widow, strong in the arms, short with fools. Mends nets, boots, and tempers; talks to the absent sea like a neighbour.
- **Andry Sull** — a caravan guard. Fought when the tower's woman took him and limps because of it; knows a little cult fire-script from a caravan job that went wrong, and knows he knows it.

Encounter: None.

The night's clock at the camp

- **Short rest — safe:** normal benefits in the warded berth; sleep still does not come deep.
- **The † DM dial** *(once per session, DM's call)*: if the table is out of gas, the berth clears **one exhaustion level** per PC and returns **one expended slot of 3rd level or lower, or one limited class resource — apply it even if they skipped the camp.** A valve, not a payment.
- **Long rest — too late:** sleep comes here and **the Drawing finishes while they sleep.** Announce the cost, then play **Too Late.** A legitimate ending.

Conditional follow-through:

Brief rest, then move (intended pace): the final phase is under way as they arrive — **Encounter 2 as written.**

Leave at once, no rest: they arrive **ahead of schedule** and interrupt the preparations (pace table above).

Camp survives with Orin protected: the *Restore* ending is materially better — his people keep a warded refuge instead of fleeing a hostile flat.

Otherwise: they know there is a keeper, a captive count, a cult operator with a ledger, and a lamp that can be put out. → **Scene 2.1.**

Act II — The Dry Bottom

~60 minutes. The seabed, the keeper, the lantern room, the clock.

Act II, Scene 2.1 — The Dry Seabed

Purpose / transition: Cross the flats, put the watchkeeper in the road, and make the optional fight solvable with a document, a phrase, or a walk-past.

Setting

- **Location:** the **Drywater** — former seabed, cracked silt walled back from the road by a fossil tideline of barnacled rock and dead coral, wrecks at anchor on dry ground. At the road's bend, the **Sarshel Light**: octagonal, ~90 ft, lower third barnacled, old waterline scored around it, lamp turning yellow-white.
- **See:** The fossil tideline, a wall of shell and coral a man high; oyster beds like paving; a three-masted wreck bolt upright, sails still furled. The door: iron-banded oak, a carved **Impilturan ward-sigil** cut *backwards*, packed with fresh ash. **On the apron of bare rock, the keepers' maintenance markings** — a long cut line and **three sigil-marks**, the last cut with the sea-kings' sign — with the tower's shadow lying across them **not moving the way the fixed sky says it should.** High in the lamp-room, a silhouette that does not move.
- **Hear:** A deep brass groan every half-minute, audible from 200 ft; salt crunching like glass; wind in the gallery. Standing still: **a very large, slow thud** through the rock about every ten seconds — something pressing up from underneath.
- **Smell:** Salt, low tide without a tide, cold iron, lamp-oil — and over it **hot metal and burnt resin.** A fire fed on purpose.
- **Sense:** *(gated)* **Detect magic** — a sea-kings' light-ward reversed at the root, *recently* and *deliberately*, on the same anchor as the seal below. **Arcana/Religion DC 13** — cut from a book, not a tradition: broken grammar, unmistakable intent. **Investigation DC 13 (or free from the log extract)** — the three alignment-marks on the gimbal ring match the three on the apron: **the lens can be turned back by hand. Passive Perception 15+** — the silhouette has not moved. **Insight DC 13** — Tamsin is defending a *person*, not a building; she thinks they are wreckers.

NPCs: Keeper Tamsin Reed (and, unseen above, Veyra Sorn).

> ***The restoration is explained before the fight.*** *By the stair the party can know the lens has* ***three alignment arms*** *— from the* ***apron markings*** *(free look, or Investigation DC 13),* ***Tamsin's log extract*** *(her own alignment procedure), or* ***Tamsin herself*** *once calmed. Hand it over: the lantern room is a fight about physical work, not a secret.*

Tamsin Reed — keeper of the Sarshel Light, enthralled †

Visual — show the handout when they first see them, and read these cues aloud:

Fifty-something, sun-cracked, in a coat black with salt.

A brass hand-lantern and a gnarled staff; other keeper’s tools hang by the doorway.

She warns you off three times before she swings, and she means all three.

She says you are **wreckers**. She says the light is hers. She will not let you up her stair.

Disposition: protective and suspicious, charmed for three months but eating and sleeping normally. Calls strangers wreckers and warns them three times. The captives' names and her own maintenance notes create visible doubt before any roll.

Personality: patient, dryly funny beneath the charm; checks lantern wicks mid-conversation, insists everyone use the stair handrail, and corrects sloppy nautical terms. Duty and affection for Orin conflict with the implanted order to guard the door. Once herself, she is horrified by the deception and immediately starts helping.

Motivations: keep the light burning, keep the stair clear. She believes it is the last thing between the Drywater and something worse — **and she is right**, which is the tragedy of the scene. Not a cultist; never recruited.

What she knows: Veyra Sorn came to her door as a ward-repairer † — a commission and a customs writ, sent "to service the old light-ward before the season turns." Tamsin believed her, let her in, opened the lamp for her, and has spent three months watching what that cost. Lucid intervals let her write, think, and **drive Orin back off the tideline** rather than let him die on her stair.

Possible outcomes and effects: talked down — Orin's extract read aloud, the **watch-words** (free, no roll), ***remove curse*** († same ruling as the snare), ***dispel magic*** **DC 15**, or **Persuasion/Insight DC 13** with the captives' names; she then hands over **lantern-key and shutter-code** and asks to come up as a witness, not a fighter. **Subdued** — non-lethal to 0 HP leaves her **unconscious and stable**, key, code, and logbook on her belt (takeable). **Walked past** — **her pursuit is bounded and stated, not magical:** the charm binds her to the tower base and she will not cross the fossil tideline; she shouts, does not follow, and makes no further attacks once they are inside. **Killed** — the light gutters, the alarm carries: **Encounter 2 starts at segment 1**, no other scaling, and the **shutter route remains available** ; recover the key and code from her belt.

Veyra Sorn — present, unseen, working above †

Unaware until the alarm or the lamp-room; three nights at the pedestals. If the alarm reaches her (Tamsin killed, alarm raised) she gains **+1 segment** and the emissary is ready. If the party comes up quietly — Tamsin calmed, blinded, or bypassed, plus stealth or *silence* on the stair — she is **surprised** and Encounter 2 opens a round early for them. Full entry in 2.2.

Encounter: Encounter 1 — *Keeper Tamsin Reed and the Turning Light* (File 2; its part 6 carries the authoritative written layout and the map).

Conditional follow-through:

Tamsin calmed or subdued: 2.2 opens with **key and code**, alarm unfired, emissary late (lighter scaling, File 2).

Tamsin killed: 2.2 starts at segment 1, no other scaling.

Party never enters the tower: play **Walk Away** — cost stated plainly, then the dawn road.

Otherwise: climb the stair. → **Scene 2.2.**

Act II, Scene 2.2 — The Lantern Chamber

Purpose / transition: The main event: a ritual with a clock, four people bound to it, one operator, one demon, and a lens the party can break, fix, or shutter. **All three answers are wins; each costs something different.**

Setting

- **Location:** the lantern room at the top of the tower — a **60-ft circular chamber** under an open brass dome and the snare's fixed sky, reached by a **stone stair rising from the south.** Layout and map: File 2, Encounter 2, part 6.

- **See: The lens at the centre** — a 10-ft brass-and-crystal mechanism on a gimbal ring, taller than a man, full of light that has nowhere to go, cradled in **three alignment arms**; **three fire-scribed pedestals** (N, E, W), each on a chalked circle of demon-names whose wax lines burn down toward the window; **four iron brackets around the lens cradle**, four people bound to them; **Veyra Sorn** between the pedestals with a fire-iron and a ledger; the light around the lens **shaped like a body** — a brute outline of brine and grit half in, half out of the glass; and on the south wall the keeper's log-hooks, the shutter lever, and the keeper's line and hoist-hooks.
- **Hear:** The lens's brass groan, continuous, pitched to a whine; Veyra's recitation, a flat patient list of names that never rises; the captives' fast shallow breathing; **and a huge, slow, wet knock from directly beneath the floor**, ten seconds apart, answering her.
- **Smell:** Lamp-oil burnt to resin, hot brass, ozone, and a **living brine smell** — deep water and blood — where there has been no water for eighty years. Under it, tallow and burnt hair.
- **Sense:** *(gated)* **Detect magic** — pedestals, lens, and seal are one circuit **facing the wrong way**; the reversal reads as a direction, not a secret. **Arcana/Religion DC 13** — the induction rite writ large: innocents named and burned to feed a breach. **Investigation DC 13** — the alignment arms carry marks matching three on the gimbal ring. **Insight DC 14** — Veyra is not stalling and not afraid; she thinks she has time, which means she is wrong about something. **Passive Perception 15+** — the pedestals feed the light, and the light feeds the floor.

NPCs: Veyra Sorn; the Brine Fiend; the Bound Four.

Veyra Sorn — cult operator of the Fraternity of Tharos †

Visual — show the handout when they first see them, and read these cues aloud:

Dark braided hair, charcoal coat with brass fittings, black gloves and an astrolabe.

Gloved hands adjust a brass instrument; a ledger and fire-iron rest on the nearby bench.

She does not shout and she does not gloat — she **recites**, a flat, patient list of names.

Around her, **three rings of names are burning in the floor.**

Disposition going in: unsurprised by armed strangers, and honest that she is not the reason they are here — **she will say the one true thing they need: the Fraternity did not bring them here.** Let the table check it, let it stand.

Personality: calm, courteous, talkative while she works; she recites rather than shouts and never gloats — she *explains*, because that is how the Fraternity recruits and because she is a scholar who thinks she is the most interesting person in the room.

Motivations — recognition, and the fear of going back empty-handed: a **Fraternity scholar** whose standing rests on being the one who opened the Sarshel Seal — the name in the ledger's margin, the operative the Demonstone remembers. The reversal cost her months; the cell gets **one window a night**; the Fraternity does not forgive a wasted season. **That fear is the lever:** offer her any way to walk away **not empty-handed** — her life, the ledger, a story that blames the weather, a promise nobody follows her — and she genuinely considers it, and keeps it exactly as long as it profits her.

Possible outcomes and effects — bargains, state-dependent; write the offer to fit the board, never against it. *Nothing freed yet:* she offers the captives, cutting two brackets herself as proof and keeping two as insurance — the party walks out with two living people and the promise of the rest, and the lens and ledger stay hers. *Captives already freed:* she cannot un-free anyone, so she offers the reverse — walk out with everyone, no pursuit, and she names **what is under the seal** and where the Fraternity's next beacons are, because a live failure who kept the lens is worth more to her than a dead success. **She never asks for a freed captive back, and does not need captives after she releases them.**

Fights, flees, dies: fights in Encounter 2, using the pedestals as cover, the clock as a hostage, the emissary as a bodyguard. **Flees** below 25 HP with the emissary gone — onto the **gallery**, and **no 90-ft drop:** the south wall carries the

keeper's gear (line and hoist-hooks for cleaning the lamp) and she takes the line over the rail and down the tower's west face, unhurried and competent, into the salt-fog. She escapes **wounded and named** and the Fraternity learns the party's faces — **let her run when the dice allow it. Killed:** the ritual does not stop on its own; her **+1** goes away and nothing else changes, and her ledger is in the party's hands.

The Brine Fiend — the seal's emissary †

Visual — show the handout when they first see them, and read these cues aloud:

The room was dry, and then it was not.

A shape made of **standing brine** — gristle, grit, and salt packed into an outline about as tall as a person and twice as wide.

A **hooked mouth** it can open much further than the rest of it.

Where it stands, the stone weeps.

Disposition going in: half-manifested, ravenous, no interest in the party as people. It wants the lens, the salt, and the four warm things on the brackets.

What it is — and is not. Keep this clean at the table: a **lesser demon and the emissary of the thing sealed**, a shape sustained by the intact, misaligned lens (the pedestals power the ritual, not its body). **It is not the Sarshel Seal's prisoner.** The prisoner is the **thing under the floor** — far larger, never manifested tonight, that slow ten-second knock. **Do not stat it, do not name it, and do not let the table think the fight in this room is with it.**

Possible outcomes and effects: killed — it breaks into **brine-slurry and one hooked glass-hard tooth** (see *Loot*) and its shape is drawn back into the seal; **the ritual is entirely unaffected and the clock keeps ticking — a fight won, not the night won**, and not permanently destroyed. **Banished** if the alignment is restored: pulled back through the resealed conduit, no corpse, no tooth. **Returned with the light** if the lens is smashed: dragged back the same way, same residue, same tooth, and the ward above it dies. **Escaped** if the clock reaches 6 with the lens intact: it walks out into the Drywater and the ending changes.

The Bound Four — the camp's missing †

- **Disposition going in:** terrified, gagged, bound to iron brackets round the lens cradle. Orin can name every one; the party met their stories at the camp.
- **What the ritual does — no automatic deaths:** at **segment 2** and again at **segment 4** it **drains** a bound captive — the rite takes warmth and breath for the pedestals and they go **unconscious and stable, not dead and not dying. The drain is reversible: if the alignment is restored, or the lens is resolved in time, drained captives wake.** At **segment 6** the seal cracks and the two still bound are in immediate, visible, reachable danger — **a rescue window with a survivable breach, never an unavoidable kill** (numbers in File 2, *Triggers*).
- **Helpful, safe tasks on rescue** *(not combatants; no stat blocks; off the board, helping only inside the party's own actions — never with invented powers):* **Halen Croy** knows the stair in the dark and counts the steps aloud, leading the freed down and out; **Merra Voss** reads the maintenance marks the way she read road signs and confirms aloud which way an arm turns; **Bett Ralen** is a second pair of hands — a body on the gimbal is a body on the gimbal; **Andry Sull** knows enough cult fire-script from a caravan job to name what burns in the floor, and to say it is answerable.
- **Possible outcomes and effects: one action at each visible safety catch, no roll**, to free them (or use bracket damage/dispel; File 2). **–1 segment per captive, once each. A freed captive cannot be killed remotely or re-taken by the ritual** — off the bracket is out of the conduit. **All currently bound captives freed, or no pedestal burning, stops the Drawing; after segment 6 the breach must also be repaired** — say it out loud; that is the reward for choosing people over damage.

Encounter: Encounter 2 — *The Lantern Chamber* (File 2).

The Lens — the objective *(an object, not a creature)*

- **Smash it:** an ordinary object, **AC 15, HP 30, damage threshold 10** — a single blow under 10 does nothing, and there is **no guaranteed three blows**; small weapons chip, spells must legally target objects. **Result:** the snare ends instantly for everyone in the mile, the emissary is dragged back into the seal, and **the old ward dies with the light** — refuge unprotected, seal left **unwarded.** Fast, cheap, permanent.
- **Restore the alignment: three arms, any order, any PC, no one-per-round limit.** Each arm is completed **either** by **one action plus a successful DC 13 check** (Arcana, Religion, Investigation, or Sleight of Hand — whatever the character is doing) **or** by **two actions with no roll at all**, working the arm across two turns; **progress persists between rounds. No accelerated spells** (*mending* keeps its 1-minute cast and is not a combat action), **no invented class powers, and no single skill gates the room** — a failed check costs a turn, never the run. **Result:** the demon threat is **banished**, the **refuge is preserved**, everyone still alive stays alive, and **drained captives wake.** A minimum of three successful actions, or six no-roll actions, distinguishes restoration from destruction; failed checks and interference can cost more.
- **Shutter it:** with **Tamsin's key and shutter-code**, the lamp is snuffed in **one action** at the south wall. **Result: the snare ends for everyone in the mile — and the Drawing does not.** The pedestals burn on their own circuit and the clock runs full speed, **no pause, no grace period.** The lever is **manual and stays where it is put**; working it back and forth buys nothing — say so the first time anyone tries.

The Drawing — the ritual clock *(one deterministic rule; identical in File 2)*

- **Resolution limits:** threshold events occur once each; a freed named target cannot be drained. After segment 6, restoration must finish within three further rounds to reseal; later repair ends the snare but leaves a regional breach. Smashing before 6 leaves an intact unwarded seal; after 6 leaves a cracked unwarded seal. Drained captives wake on restoration/destruction of the lens, ordinary healing, or an hour of care outside the snare. These limits apply to every ending below.
- **Clock start:** Veyra starts the six-segment breach at true dawn (three hours after landing), or rushes it early when confronted in the lantern room. An alarm readies her but does not itself start the clock. If unopposed after dawn, she advances twice per round and completes it in three rounds. During a played confrontation use normal initiative; elapsed time still matters if the party retreats. Start at 0; an announced alarm adds 1 once, never stacks. If the rite has already completed, use the breach aftermath, not a fresh clock.
- **Advance:** +1 at the end of each round while at least one captive is bound AND at least one pedestal burns. Veyra may spend her action for +1 under the same conditions. Maximum +2 per round. If either condition fails the clock stops; Veyra cannot restart it by herself.
- **Veyra's action:** if she works the rite, **+1 more, once per round, maximum. Cap: +2 in any round. The emissary can never advance it.**
- **Setbacks, each counted once and never farmed:** freeing a captive **−1** (per captive, once — a freed captive is out of the conduit and cannot be re-bound to be freed again); destroying a pedestal **−1** (per pedestal, once). **Minimum 0.**
- **Stop:** no captives remain bound OR no pedestal burns. The counter freezes; no creature can reactivate destroyed pedestals or rebind a rescued captive during this encounter. Stopping after 6 does not repair the breach; use the three-round recovery window.
- **At 6:** no automatic death. The party has three further rounds to repair the lens and reseal the breach; smashing it halts the conduit but leaves a cracked seal. After that, the regional breach persists even if the lens is resolved; the stair stays open for rescue or retreat. Apply only the written floor hazard, not a surprise explosion.

Ending the session

Outcome	How	Cost	Carried out
The Light Turned Back	All three arms completed	At least 3 successful actions or 6 no-roll actions, plus interference; *Counter-Ward* can undo an arm per round	Demon **banished**; refuge **preserved**; drained captives **wake**; seal sealed; Fraternity named, not ended
The Glass Broken	Lens to 0 HP	The old ward dies: refuge gone, seal **unwarded** — deferred, not solved	Every lured traveller freed at once; emissary **returned**; slurry and tooth as evidence; an intact but unwarded seal nine miles from a city
The Lamp Shuttered	Key + code, one action	Snare ends; **the ritual does not**, and does not pause	A dark lantern room, pedestals still burning, and a race — smash, restore, or clear out
The Drawing Completed	Clock 6 with the lens intact, or a long rest through the window	Seal cracks; demonic pressure bleeds into the Drywater	The *Too Late* flight east — survivors, evidence, a live incursion behind them
The Walk Away	Party crosses the boundary without resolving the tower	Veyra can finish at dawn unless someone intervenes; camp residents can evacuate if persuaded or warned	Freedom and whatever people/evidence the party actually brought; no forced return or surprise punishment

Aftermath: ending the snare reveals the actual sky; it does not advance time. If the party wins early, dawn still lies ahead. Rescued survivors can rest, evacuate, or keep the restored waystation. Merra offers introductions to honest traders in New Sarshel; evidence can earn a hearing rather than predetermined rejection. New Sarshel is nine miles east of the tower (about three hours at normal pace, longer with injured people). Veyra's contacts are available only if the party obtained her ledger or questioned her. The Demonstone tower is published canon (CG p. 145), but its identity is not automatically player knowledge. Close on departure or shelter according to player choices.

Conditional follow-through:

Restored: local ward and seal repaired; surviving NPC relationships and recovered evidence become future opportunities. Orin can keep the waystation. City addresses are a lead only if actually acquired.

Smashed: the **seal is unwarded**; the refuge must move and the wreck is abandoned. Carry forward: **an open seal** under a road nine miles from a city of thirty thousand, the **tooth** as evidence, and **what became of Tamsin Reed.**

Shuttered only: the **Drawing runs on** — a short clock in a dark room, the seal the live stake.

Completed: the **seal cracks** and demonic pressure bleeds into the Drywater. Carry forward: **an active incursion nine miles from New Sarshel**, Orin's survivors walking east.

Veyra escaped: she can report what she actually saw, subject to her survival and choices. She does not automatically know who holds the ledger. If captured, interrogation may reveal leads. Killing her does not transfer equipment remotely; recovery still requires searching the room.

Campaign-wide: no Shadowdale, no Sela, no fey resolution — the drow threat under Old Skull stays live, Oberon's disposition unknown, and Yinu's cipher book, Naan's letter, and the Vhaeraunian clock all tick.

Rest & Recovery in the Snare †

No automatic rest. The party comes off the Feywild with whatever they had when Sela cut the ribbon; the landing costs them nothing, but nothing in the mile hands them sleep either.

Situation	What they get
Open ground	Normal rest rules; exposure and the announced dawn deadline matter, not magical insomnia
Camp	Food, shelter, first aid, and a normal short rest. No automatic recovery of spell slots or class resources beyond the characters' actual abilities
The camp, long rest (8 hrs)	Sleep comes — and **the Drawing finishes while they sleep.** Announce first, then play *Too Late*
After the lens is resolved	Ground is normal: **a long rest is available**, as the falling action

> ***Weariness is texture, not a punishment.*** *Nothing retro-punishes a rest the table already took, and nothing spirals: if they arrive genuinely out of gas, hand them the dial and run the fight they came for.*

Threads Left Open — Do Not Resolve Tonight

- **Sela Wyndmere** — alive, taken, or destroyed: **unknown**; last seen in the Bright Court as the party launched. **Leave it open.**
- **Shadowdale and the drow** — the suppression broke when Sela cut the ribbon; the Vhaeraunian threat beneath Old Skull is live and uninhibited, and the dale has no warning. **Unreachable tonight.**
- **Oberon** — scattered, **not dead**. **Also open:** Yinu's Harper cipher book (possibly compromised) · Naan's undisclosed Lathander letter · Quillip (not on this road) · the Vhaeraunian retaliation clock · the third cleft · Lady Ulphor's S5 payment.

Loot & Rewards Summary

- **No promised payment or contract.** Recovered personal effects and Veyra’s 15 gp are loot; aid from survivors depends on how the party treated them.
- **Veyra's ledger** — fire-script demon-names, the rite's grammar, and **three New Sarshel addresses**: evidence, a map into the city, proof of the reverse-warding method.
- **Tamsin's logbook and lantern-key** — three months of testimony plus the shutter key and code. **The original log stays in the tower; Orin's extract travels.**
- **Orin’s ward-nail (DM ADDITION):** suppresses this lighthouse’s illusions within 10 ft while the old ward survives. It does not grant general resistance to unrelated magic. Orin offers its use for evacuation; it goes inert if the lens is smashed.
- **Brine residue:** killing the emissary or smashing the lens leaves brine and one hooked tooth (roughly 50 gp as a trophy; trade in demon trophies is canon, CG p.145). Restoration or extinction of the conduit after repair leaves no tooth. Loot requires actual collection; it does not appear in a pack automatically.
- **The freed captives** and the addresses: the real reward, and a debt instrument aimed at the **Fraternity of Tharos**.

XP / Milestone

- **No at-the-table level-up, ever.** Sheets stay **L6**; milestones are applied **between sessions**.
- **Thresholds (5×L6; 2014 DMG per-PC 300/600/900/1,400):** Easy 1,500 · Medium 3,000 · Hard 4,500 · Deadly 7,000.
- **Encounter 1:** Tamsin Reed (**CR 5 provisional**, 1,800 × 1.0) = **1,800** → **Easy-to-Medium *(provisional)***. Optional, non-lethal by default.
- **Encounter 2:** Veyra (**CR 6 provisional**, 2,300) + Brine Fiend (**CR 5 provisional**, 1,800) = 4,100 × **1.5** = **6,150** → **Hard *(provisional)***, just under Deadly.
- **Night total ~7,950 adjusted** against the party's **daily budget of 20,000** (5 × 4,000 at L6) — about **two-fifths of an adventuring day** with one short rest; no need to compress the fights to fit.
- **Honesty note:** those three CRs are **budget ratings chosen to size the fights, not verified DMG-derived calculations** — every band stays **provisional** until it sees the table.
- **Milestone earned; apply between sessions**, never as a live beat.

DM Additions Flagged for Guide Canonization

All local lighthouse locations, NPCs, ward/ritual mechanics, and specific clues are **DM ADDITIONS**. Impiltur, New Sarshel, and the Fraternity of Tharos are sourced to CG p. 145. The Drawing is an invented nonlethal-draining variant, not the sourcebook's induction rite. Campaign guide proposals require revision to match this edition before adoption; session history remains unchanged until play.

Combat Tracker — The Lighthouse on Dry Land

Two encounters — an optional keeper confrontation and a finale the party may resolve, negotiate, or leave. Encounter 1 is **optional and non-lethal by default**: the enthralled watchkeeper can be calmed with a document, a phrase, or ***remove curse***, or simply walked past. Encounter 2 is the session's objective — a ritual on a six-segment clock, four bound captives, a cult operator, and a lesser demon.

Party: five PCs at Level 6. 2014 DMG per-PC thresholds — **Easy 300 · Medium 600 · Hard 900 · Deadly 1,400** — so at **5 PCs**: **Easy 1,500 · Medium 3,000 · Hard 4,500 · Deadly 7,000.** Every stat block is † **homebrew with a provisional budget CR**: the CR is a budget rating chosen to size the fight, **not a verified DMG-derived defensive/offensive calculation.** Treat every difficulty band as **provisional. No PC is ever written into a card or a handout** — Juniper's character's name goes in the blank initiative rows and nowhere else.

> ***Tactical maps are generated.*** *The written distances and terrain rules below remain authoritative if the artwork differs. Both maps are stored locally; exact prompts are in* `images/images.json`.

Encounter 1 — Keeper Tamsin Reed and the Turning Light

Act II, Scene 2.1 · Optional, non-lethal by default · Easy-to-Medium (provisional) (1,800 XP / Easy 1,500 – Medium 3,000 at 5×L6)

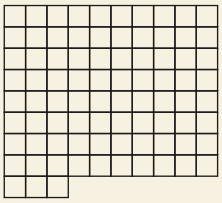
Summary

Location	The Drywater, at the foot of the **Sarshel Light** — the fossil tideline and the tower's south door, on the road's bend.
Light	The lamp turning overhead; the snare's fixed moon; salt-fog to 120 ft. The lamp is a light source the DM can dim (*Guttering*, below).
Terrain	Cracked silt flat; a chest-high **fossil tideline** (half cover, Climb 10 ft, 15-ft gap at the east end); two **beached wrecks** (full and half cover); three **anchor posts** (half cover); the tower's **40-ft stone drum** with one south door.
Antagonists	1× **Keeper Tamsin Reed** (CR 5 provisional, †) + the **Turning Light** (lair actions)
Party	**5 PCs at L6** — Nalith, Naan, Kto, Yinu, and **Juniper's character** (name/build open).
XP	1,800 × 1.0 (single creature) = **1,800 → Easy-to-Medium *(provisional)***. A 2–3 round fight that can be avoided entirely.
Duration	3 rounds or fewer. She **yields the moment any calm-down route lands** — the DM should be looking for the exit, not the grind.
Goal (PCs)	Get up the stair — or get Tamsin back.
Goal (Tamsin)	Keep them off her stair and away from her lamp. **She thinks they are wreckers** — the old coastal crime — and she is defending a *person*, not a building.
Non-lethal by default	She fights to subdue: **she never strikes an unconscious creature**, and any hit of hers that would drop a PC can be narrated as the flat of the hook.
Skip condition	Five ways past her with no fight — the log extract, the watch-words, *remove curse*, *dispel magic* DC 15, or **walking around her. Her pursuit is bounded and stated, not magical:** the charm binds her to the tower base and she will not cross the fossil tideline. The entrance is unbarred: use normal movement and any applicable opportunity attack to pass her apron; she does not pursue upstairs.

Round Strip & Initiative

Round: ☐1 ☐2 ☐3 ☐4 ☐5 ☐6 ☐7 ☐8 ☐9 ☐10

NPC initiative is pre-rolled (`round(avg(1d20 + DEX))`). PCs roll live and write into the blank rows.

Init	Combatant	AC	HP	Notes
__	_____	__	_____	_____
__	_____	__	_____	_____
__	_____	__	_____	_____
12	Keeper Tamsin Reed	16	**85** 	**Charmed by the light** (*remove curse* / *dispel magic* DC 15 ends it) · **Ward-Bound** to the tower's mile · **Bloodied 42** (she starts talking) · key, code, and logbook on her belt — **takeable if she is unconscious**
__	_____	__	_____	_____
__	_____	__	_____	_____

Conditions: Bln · Chr · Deaf · Frt · Grp · Inc · Inv · Prl · Pet · Pzn · Prn · Rst · Stn · Uns · Conc

Triggers & Countdowns

- **Calm her (the intended ending).** Any one of these ends the fight on the spot: **Orin's log extract read aloud** (free, no roll); the **watch-words** call-and-response (Orin has them on the flyleaf; free if the party asked him in Scene 1.2); ***remove curse*** († homebrew ruling — the charm is the reversed ward's hold, and the table already used this call on Oberon's thrall in S6); ***dispel magic*** **DC 15**; **Persuasion or Insight DC 13** while showing her the captives' names or the ledger page. **Calmed, she hands over lantern-key and shutter-code** and comes up as a witness, not a fighter.
- **Bloodied (≤42 HP).** She stops swinging, backs to her door, and starts *listening* — every calm-down route lands automatically. Give the table the beat.
- **Non-lethal resolution (†).** Any hit of hers that would reduce a PC to 0 HP leaves them at **1 HP and prone** instead. Knock *her* out with non-lethal damage and she is **unconscious, stable, alive** — key, code, and logbook on her belt.
- **Walk past her.** Once the party is inside, **she does not pursue upstairs** — she shouts the truth at their backs and holds the doorway. Her standing order keeps her on the exterior apron; she chooses to hold it rather than pursue upstairs.
- **Killed.** If Tamsin dies, **the light gutters and the alarm carries: Encounter 2 begins with the ritual clock at segment 1 already banked.** No other scaling — a setback, not a death sentence — and the **shutter route remains available** ; recover the key and code from her belt.
- **The Turning Light (lair actions, initiative 20).** While the lamp burns, one per round: **Lamp-Flash** — one creature in line of sight, **DEX DC 13** or **blinded until the end of its next turn**. **The Longing** — one creature, **WIS DC 13** or it sees its longing and has **disadvantage on its next attack roll**; on a success it gains the ***disbelieving*** tag (recognition that the visions are false; it does not itself dispel magic). **Guttering** — a 15-ft radius around Tamsin is **heavily obscured** until the next initiative 20.
- **Do not stall this scene.** If the dice are grinding, she goes bloodied and starts talking, or the lamp gutters and she loses a turn. The night's real clock lives upstairs.

- **What she knows (free, if calmed): Veyra Sorn came to her door as a ward-repairer** † — a commission and a customs writ, "to service the old light-ward before the season turns." She let her in, opened the lamp for her, and has watched the cost for three months. She also knows she has **turned Orin Vale back off the tideline twice** — non-lethally — and hates that she did.

Tactics Summary

- **Keeper Tamsin Reed** — R1: three warnings, then **Boat-Hook** at the lead PC (or **Lamp-Spark Flare** if two or more crowd her). R2: **Wrenching Drag** whoever is closest to the stair back into the open. R3+: yield to any calm-down route; otherwise hold the doorway and let the *Turning Light* work. **She never leaves the tower base and never pursues a downed PC.**
- **The Turning Light** — one lair action per round at initiative 20. Prefer *The Longing* early (it hands the table the snare's rules for free) and *Lamp-Flash* when a caster is lining up at the door.

Loot / Aftermath

- **Tamsin's kit:** key, written shutter-code, original logbook, ordinary patched coat, lantern, staff, and a mundane bent nail. Her cold resistance is a ward effect, not transferable armor.
- **Alive and calmed**, she is the session's best witness and comes up the stair with them. **Unconscious**, the key and code come off her belt. **Dead**, she is a name in the post-play log and the party's own alarm.
- **No coin.** She has served under the charm for three months and paid in nothing.

Keeper Tamsin Reed

> *Weathered keeper with windblown silver hair, patched blue-green coat, rope belt, brass lantern, and a gnarled staff. Her boat-hook and wrench hang beside the doorway and come out if she fights.*

Medium humanoid (human), Lawful Neutral (charmed), † **homebrew · CR 5 provisional budget rating (1,800 XP)** *— a budget rating set to size this fight against a 5×L6 party, not a DMG-derived CR calculation; run it loosely.*

AC	16 (keeper's oilskin and plate-scrap over leather)
HP	**85** (10d8 + 40) · **Bloodied 42**
Speed	30 ft.
STR / DEX / CON	16 (+3) · 12 (+1) · 18 (+4)
INT / WIS / CHA	11 (+0) · 14 (+2) · 12 (+1)
Saves	STR +6, CON +7
Skills	Athletics +6, Perception +5, Survival +5
Resistances	Cold
Condition Immunities	None; the lighthouse charm is a specific homebrew effect, not general immunity to charm or fear
Senses	Passive Perception 15
Languages	Common, Chondathan

Traits. ***Charmed by the Light*** † — the reversed ward's hold. Ends on ***remove curse*** (no roll), ***dispel magic*** **DC 15**, or any calm-down route. When it breaks she is herself: exhausted, appalled, useful. ***Ward-Bound*** † — she cannot willingly move more than **200 ft from the tower base**, and she will not cross the **fossil tideline** (≈50 ft out from her door) at all;

her pursuit is bounded, visible, and never a magical vanish. ***Keeper's Restraint*** † — she fights to subdue: any hit of hers that would drop a creature to 0 HP leaves it at **1 HP and prone**, and she never strikes an unconscious creature.

Actions. ***Multiattack.*** Two **Boat-Hook** attacks, or one Boat-Hook and one **Wrenching Drag**. ***Boat-Hook.*** Melee, reach 10 ft., **+6**, **1d8 + 3 piercing** plus **1d6 lightning** (lamp-spark). ***Wrenching Drag.*** Melee, reach 10 ft., **+6**, 1d4 + 3 bludgeoning, and **STR DC 14** or the target is **pulled 10 ft.** toward her and **grappled** (escape DC 14). ***Lamp-Spark Flare (Recharge 5–6)*** † — she throws her hand-lamp's aperture open: **20-ft cone**, **DEX DC 14**, **4d6 radiant**, half on a success, and a failure is also **blinded until the end of its next turn**.

Bonus Actions. ***Keeper's Shove.*** **STR DC 14** against a creature within 5 ft. — push 10 ft. and no reactions until the start of its next turn.

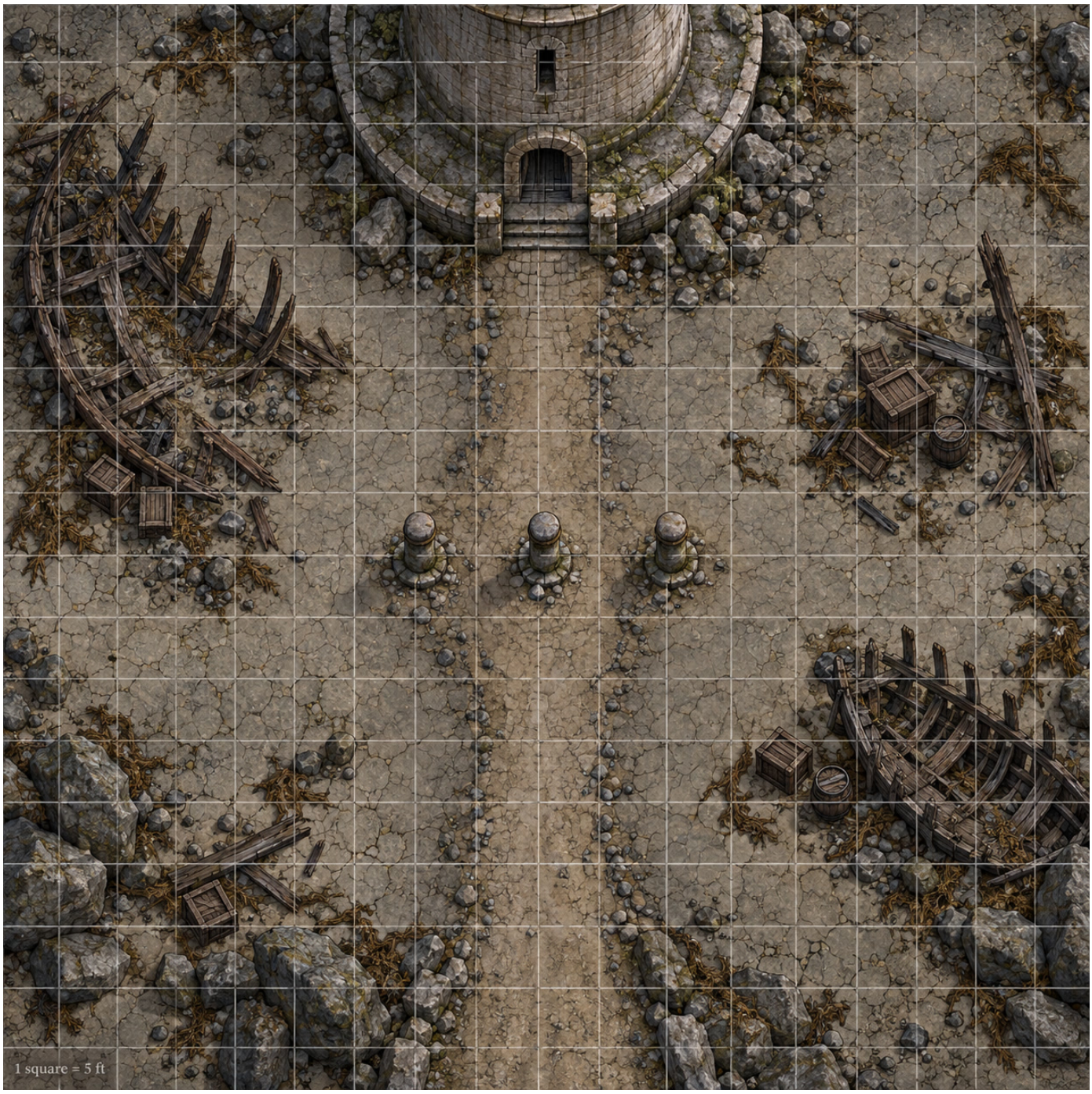
Reactions. ***Parry the Wrench.*** +3 AC against one melee attack that hits her. Once per round.

On defeat (subdued). Unconscious and stable, key and code on her belt. When she wakes — calmed or not — she wants to know what the party found upstairs, and she believes whatever the log says.

Encounter 1 — Tactical Layout *(written dimensions remain authoritative)*

Grid: 1 square = 5 ft. Field is 80 ft. × 80 ft. (road to door), north up. PCs enter from the south edge.

- **The Salt Way (south edge).** 20 ft. wide across the field's south side; the road bends north at the tower.
- **The fossil tideline (mid-field, east–west).** Chest-high wall 30 ft. north of the road. **Half cover; Climb 10 ft. across; a 15-ft gap at the field's east end** where the road bends through — the intended approach.
- **Wreck A (west, north of the tideline).** 25 × 15 ft. hull on its side — **full cover, climbable**, ribs making a 10-ft pocket of dim light. **Wreck B (east, south of the tideline).** 20 × 10 ft., angled — half cover; blocks the road-to-door line.
- **Three anchor posts** (stone bollards, 4 ft.) at the field's centre, 15 ft. apart — half cover.
- **The tower base.** A **40-ft-diameter stone drum** at north-centre with a **south door**; a **40 × 15 ft. bare-rock apron** fronts it.
- **Tamsin starts 20 ft. south of the door**, on the apron, between the party and the stair. She retreats to the doorway at bloodied and never crosses the tideline.
- **Distances:** road → tideline **30 ft.**; tideline gap → door **50 ft.**; door → stair foot **10 ft.** (inside); road → door **80 ft.**
- **Light:** the turning lamp — bright on the apron, dim beyond 30 ft.; the fixed moon (dim) elsewhere. *Guttering* drops the apron to heavily obscured for a round.
- **Vertical:** tideline is a chest-high obstacle (climb costs normal extra movement); wrecks 15 ft and 10 ft; tower 90 ft high. The door is the obvious entry, but climbing, ropes, or available flight can reach the gallery.


1 square = 5 ft

Encounter 2 — The Lantern Chamber

Act II, Scene 2.2 · Hard (provisional) (6,150 adjusted XP / Hard 4,500 – Deadly 7,000 at 5×L6)

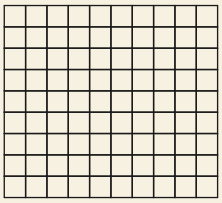
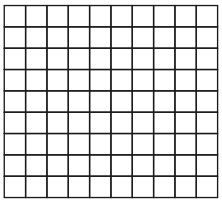
Summary

Location	The lantern room at the top of the **Sarshel Light** — a 60-ft circular chamber under an open brass dome, five feet of gallery outside the glass.
Light	The lens is the only light: brilliant, white-yellow, full of nowhere to go. Bright light in the centre 20 ft., dim to the walls; the snare's fixed night above.
Terrain	**60-ft chamber; central 10-ft lens on a gimbal cradle; three fire-scribed pedestals (N, E, W; 5 ft. wide, half cover); four captive brackets inside the cradle ring; the stone stair rises from the south; a 5-ft gallery ring with a 3-ft parapet.**
Antagonists	1× **Veyra Sorn** (CR 6 provisional, †) + 1× **Brine Fiend** (CR 5 provisional, †) + the ritual clock
Objects	**Sarshel Glass** (AC 15 / HP 30, threshold 10) · 3× **Fire-Scribed Pedestal** (AC 15 / HP 20) · 4× **Iron Bracket** (AC 12 / HP 10)
Party	**5 PCs at L6** — Nalith, Naan, Kto, Yinu, Juniper's character.
XP	2,300 + 1,800 = 4,100 × **1.5** = **6,150** → **Hard *(provisional)***, just under Deadly.
Duration	Six clock segments; typically 4–7 rounds of combat.
Goal (PCs)	Free the four captives, break the ritual, and **deal with the lens** — smash, restore, or shutter.
Goal (Veyra)	Finish the Drawing. She will spend the party's lives to do it, and she will bargain while she works.
Goal (Brine Fiend)	Get fully into the world and eat what is on the brackets.
Arrival state	More than one hour before dawn: third pedestal inactive for this encounter, emissary appears round 2 and is half-manifested that round. Final hour: all three lit, fiend present and half-manifested round 1. Surprise follows ordinary stealth rules. Alarm starts clock at 1 once when Veyra begins; no extra rest penalty. After completion at dawn: use breach aftermath instead of resetting clock
Scaling down (lighter)	Party arrives genuinely out of gas: the Brine Fiend starts at **45 HP** and skips *Drowning Grasp* on round 1. The clock rule never changes.

Round Strip & Initiative

Round: ☐1 ☐2 ☐3 ☐4 ☐5 ☐6 ☐7 ☐8 ☐9 ☐10

Ritual clock — the Drawing: [ ] 1 · [ ] 2 · [ ] 3 · [ ] 4 · [ ] 5 · [ ] 6 *(one deterministic rule — see Triggers)*

Init	Combatant	AC	HP	Notes
__	_____	__	_____	_____
__	_____	__	_____	_____
__	_____	__	_____	_____
13	Veyra Sorn	16	**90** 	**Advances the Drawing +1 (once/round max)** · *Warded by the Ritual* while ≥1 pedestal burns · ***Counter-Ward*** reaction (once/round) · flees below 25 HP if the fiend is gone
13	Brine Fiend	15	**90** 	Half-manifested in round 1 (advantage against it, no reactions) · **no ritual action — never advances the clock**
__	_____	__	_____	_____
__	_____	__	_____	_____

Conditions: Bln · Chr · Deaf · Frt · Grp · Inc · Inv · Prl · Pet · Pzn · Prn · Rst · Stn · Uns · Conc

Triggers & Countdowns

The Drawing — one deterministic rule (all four files agree). Six segments; mark a box per segment. **Thresholds trigger only the first time reached, even if the counter falls and rises again. A named drain target already freed is unaffected; do not substitute another captive.**

- **Resolution limits:** threshold events occur once each; a freed named target cannot be drained. After segment 6, restoration must finish within three further rounds to reseal; later repair ends the snare but leaves a regional breach. Smashing before 6 leaves an intact unwarded seal; after 6 leaves a cracked unwarded seal. Drained captives wake on restoration/destruction of the lens, ordinary healing, or an hour of care outside the snare. These limits apply to every ending below.
- **Clock start:** Veyra starts the six-segment breach at true dawn (three hours after landing), or rushes it early when confronted in the lantern room. An alarm readies her but does not itself start the clock. If unopposed after dawn, she advances twice per round and completes it in three rounds. During a played confrontation use normal initiative; elapsed time still matters if the party retreats. Start at 0; an announced alarm adds 1 once, never stacks. If the rite has already completed, use the breach aftermath, not a fresh clock.
- **Advance:** +1 at the end of each round while at least one captive is bound AND at least one pedestal burns. Veyra may spend her action for +1 under the same conditions. Maximum +2 per round. If either condition fails the clock stops; Veyra cannot restart it by herself.
- **Veyra's action: +1 more — once per round, maximum. Cap: +2 in any round. The Brine Fiend has no ritual action and can never advance it.**

- **Setbacks, each counted once and never farmed: free a captive −1** (per captive, once — off the bracket is out of the conduit, and a freed captive cannot be re-bound to be freed again); **destroy a pedestal −1** (per pedestal, once). **Minimum 0.**
- **Stop:** no captives remain bound OR no pedestal burns. The counter freezes; no creature can reactivate destroyed pedestals or rebind a rescued captive during this encounter. Stopping after 6 does not repair the breach; use the three-round recovery window.

Seg	Effect
1	The light tightens; shadows lengthen. Everyone sees their longing, briefly — **no save, no forced action; name what each PC wants and move on.**
2	**Halen Croy** (bargeman's boy, twelve) is **drained** at the cradle. He goes **unconscious and stable — not dead, not dying.**
3	The pedestals blaze: the **Brine Fiend heals 15 HP** *or* gains advantage on its next attack (its choice).
4	**Merra Voss** (pedlar) is **drained** — **unconscious and stable**, same as Halen.
5	The floor's slow knock becomes a **crack**: a 10-ft fissure opens from the cradle toward the south stair — **difficult terrain**, and a creature entering it makes a **DEX DC 13** save or takes **2d6 acid** and falls **prone**.
6	Seal cracks; no instant deaths. The fiend is still tied to the lens. Resolve the lens within **three further rounds** to contain the breach: restoration reseals it; destruction stops the conduit but leaves a cracked, unwarded seal. After those three rounds the pressure stabilizes as a regional hazard, not an unavoidable explosion. The stair remains usable; release and carry any remaining captives. Later lens destruction can end the snare but cannot repair the breach

> ***Drained captives are not dead.*** *The rite takes warmth and breath for the pedestals, and it is* ***reversible: if the alignment is restored — or the lens is otherwise resolved in time — drained captives wake.*** *No segment kills anyone outright, and* ***a freed captive cannot be killed remotely or re-taken by the ritual.***

The three answers to the lens: smash it, **restore the alignment**, or **shutter the lamp** — full rules on the object cards at the end of this encounter, and the four-file-identical clock rule above. **Result of any of them: the snare ends in the mile; only what happens to the ward differs.**

> ***Fair objectives:*** *releasing a captive always succeeds with an action. Destroying a pedestal requires enough damage; hitting it or the lens does not automatically lower the clock. Restoration has a slower no-roll method. Telegraph risks before choices; a failed check never automatically kills a captive.*

Tactics Summary

- **Veyra Sorn** — R1: **Advance the Drawing** (action) plus her one true line — *"We didn't bring you here"* — positioned so the cradle sits between her and the party's melee. R2: ***demon-name*** into the densest pair, and hold ***Counter-Ward*** for the first arm a PC completes. R3: ***fear*** on the front line, or ***banishment*** on whoever is clearly turning the lens (a minute in a harmless demiplane — a problem, not a death sentence). R4+: below **25 HP with the fiend gone**, she takes the **keeper's line off the south-wall hoist-hooks and goes over the gallery rail — down the tower's west face, unhurried and competent, into the salt-fog. Let her run; she is a recurring antagonist.**

- **Brine Fiend** — R1: **half-manifested** (advantage against it; no reactions) — it bites **whoever is nearest the brackets**, because the ritual is the only thing holding it in the world. R2+: **keep the party off the mechanism** — ***Drowning Grasp*** on a caster or on whoever is working an arm, and **interpose between the party and Veyra** (she is its ticket into the world). **It has no ritual action and never advances the clock.**
- **Keeper Tamsin Reed** *(if she came up calmed)* — she does not fight. She holds the stair, moves freed captives down it, and shouts the lamp's geometry at the party (free *investigation* of the alignment marks the first time anyone looks: **no roll**).

Loot / Aftermath

- **Veyra Sorn's ledger** — demon-names in fire-script, the Drawing's grammar, and **three New Sarshel addresses**: the session's most valuable object.
- **Veyra's kit:** 15 gp, ordinary charcoal coat with brass fittings, ledger, astrolabe, ritual sigil, and two alchemist's fire vials. Fire resistance comes from her pact, not lootable armor.
- **Brine residue:** killing the emissary or smashing the lens leaves brine and one hooked tooth (roughly 50 gp as a trophy; trade in demon trophies is canon, CG p.145). Restoration or extinction of the conduit after repair leaves no tooth. Loot requires actual collection; it does not appear in a pack automatically.
- **The Sarshel Seal** — **restored:** sealed, ward intact. **Smashed:** unwarded and still there. Either way, record the state in the post-play log; it is the thread the next session inherits.
- **The four Impilturans — Halen Croy, Merra Voss, Bett Ralen, Andry Sull. Alive, unconscious, or carried out — not a body count:** whoever is alive is alive, drained captives wake if the ward was restored, and anyone lost was lost to the table's choices, not to a script. Orin Vale can name all four. **This is the aftermath that matters.**

Veyra Sorn

> *Dark braided hair, charcoal high-collared coat with brass fittings, black gloves, and an astrolabe. A ledger rests on the workbench. She recites names under her breath and straightens her cuffs when frightened; her fire-iron is a ritual tool within reach.*

Medium humanoid (human), Lawful Evil, † homebrew · CR 6 provisional budget rating (2,300 XP) — *budget rating, not a DMG-derived CR calculation; run it loosely.*

AC	16 (fire-hardened leather over a warded sigil-plate)
HP	**90** (12d8 + 36)
Speed	30 ft.
STR / DEX / CON	11 (+0) · 14 (+2) · 16 (+3)
INT / WIS / CHA	14 (+2) · 14 (+2) · 16 (+3)
Saves	CON +6, WIS +5, CHA +6
Skills	Arcana +5, Deception +6, Intimidation +6, Religion +5
Resistances	Fire
Senses	Darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 12
Languages	Common, Infernal

Traits. Advance the Drawing: action, +1 once per round only while a captive remains bound and a pedestal burns. **Warded by the Ritual:** three active pedestals grant radiant resistance and advantage on saves against spells; two grant only radiant resistance; one or zero grant neither. **Ambitious and Afraid:** Veyra wants recognition from her superiors, fears returning empty-handed, and considers a bargain that preserves her life or research. She did not cause the party's portal.

Actions. ***Multiattack.*** Two Fire-Iron attacks. Casting a spell or advancing the rite instead consumes her action. ***Fire-Iron Brand.*** Melee, **+7**, **1d8 + 3 bludgeoning** plus **2d6 fire**. ***Demon-Name (Recharge 5–6)*** † **— 30-ft cone**, **DEX DC 15**, **6d6 fire**, half on a success; on a failure the target is **marked** and the Brine Fiend deals **+1d6 acid** to it until the end of Veyra's next turn.

Spellcasting. Charisma-based homebrew spellcaster (**DC 15, +6 to hit**; bespoke slots): **Cantrips** *fire bolt, thaumaturgy, minor illusion* · **1st (4):** [ ] [ ] [ ] [ ] *bane, hellish rebuke, shield of faith* · **2nd (3):** [ ] [ ] [ ] *darkness, scorching ray, hold person* · **3rd (2):** [ ] [ ] *dispel magic, fear* · **4th (1):** [ ] *banishment*.

Bonus Actions. ***Ledger's Margin.*** One creature within 60 ft.: **WIS DC 15** or **disadvantage on its next saving throw** before the end of her next turn.

Reactions (one reaction per round total). Counter-Ward: after one alignment arm is completed within 30 ft, its worker makes WIS DC 15; failure undoes that arm and its progress. It can affect at most one arm per round. Resolve this before testing whether all three arms are aligned. **Fling the Sigil:** when hit by a melee attack within 5 ft, deal 1d6 fire to that attacker instead. Neither reaction gives a second reaction.

On defeat. Killed: the ledger, 15 gp, the coat, the sigil, and the alchemist's fire are on her — **and the ritual does not stop on its own.** Escaped: note her as a **live antagonist**; the Fraternity now knows the party's faces.

Brine Fiend

> *It comes up out of the lens light as a shape of standing brine — gristle, grit, and salt packed into an outline about as tall as a person and twice as wide, with a hooked mouth it can open further than the rest of it. Where it stands, the stone weeps. Where it bites, the wound fills with saltwater that will not stop running.*

Medium fiend (demon), Chaotic Evil, † **homebrew · CR 5 provisional budget rating (1,800 XP)** — *budget rating, not a DMG-derived CR calculation; average multiattack ~26.5/round (bite ~13.5, claws ~6.5 each).*

AC	15 (packed brine and grit)
HP	**90** (12d8 + 36)
Speed	30 ft., climb 20 ft., swim 40 ft.
STR / DEX / CON	16 (+3) · 14 (+2) · 16 (+3)
INT / WIS / CHA	7 (–2) · 12 (+1) · 8 (–1)
Saves	CON +6, WIS +4
Skills	Athletics +6, Perception +4
Resistances	Cold, fire, lightning; bludgeoning, piercing, slashing from nonmagical attacks
Immunities	Poison
Condition Immunities	Charmed, frightened, poisoned
Senses	Darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 14
Languages	Abyssal; telepathy 60 ft. (understands Common, cannot speak)

Traits. Half-Manifested: attacks against it have advantage and it cannot react on its first round present (round 1 normally, round 2 for early arrival). **Brine Reek:** a creature starting its turn within 10 ft makes CON DC 13 or is poisoned until its turn ends. **Amorphous Slip:** can move through a gap as narrow as 1 inch without squeezing.

The distinction that matters † **— keep it clean at the table. This fiend is a lesser demon and the seal's emissary** — a shape sustained by the intact, misaligned lens (the pedestals power the ritual, not its body). **It is not the Sarshel Seal's prisoner.** The prisoner is the **thing under the floor**: far larger, never manifested tonight, audible as that slow ten-second knock. **Never stat it, never name it, and never let the table think the fight in this room is with it.**

Actions. ***Multiattack.*** One **Bite** and two **Claw** attacks. ***Bite.*** Melee, **+6**, **2d6 + 3 piercing** plus **1d6 acid**; on a hit, **CON DC 13** or the target **loses 1 Hit Die of healing** until the end of a long rest († — the wound runs salt; flavour, not a condition). ***Claw.*** Melee, **+6**, **1d6 + 3 slashing**. ***Drowning Grasp (Recharge 5–6)*** † — melee, reach 10 ft., **+6**; on a hit the target is **grappled (escape DC 14) and restrained**, takes **2d6 acid** at the start of each of its turns, and cannot speak or use verbal components while held.

Reactions. ***Salt Spit.*** When a creature hits it in melee: **DEX DC 13** or **blinded until the end of its next turn**.

If Veyra dies, or the fiend dies. The demon does not work the ritual and **killing it does not stop the Drawing** — the end-of-round **+1** still ticks while a captive is bound and a pedestal burns. **The lens is the objective, always.** Killing the fiend is **a fight won, not the night won.**

On defeat. It collapses into **brine-slurry and one hooked, glass-hard tooth** — and its shape is **drawn back into the seal: it is returned, not permanently destroyed** (the thing under the floor keeps its leash). **If the alignment is restored**, it is instead **banished** — dragged back through the resealed conduit, screaming through water that isn't there, leaving no corpse and no tooth (subject to the post-breach recovery window). **If the lens is smashed**, it is **dragged back the same way** — same residue, same tooth — and the ward above it dies.

The Sarshel Glass (objective — not a combatant)

> *Ten feet of brass ring, crystal, and old Impilturan ironwork on a gimbal cradle, turning a light with nothing to warn. Three alignment arms stand out from the cradle, marked with the sea-kings' sigils; Veyra has packed two of them with burning ash.*

AC	15
HP	**30 — damage threshold 10:** attacks dealing less than 10 don't reduce it. **No guaranteed three blows.**
Immunities	Poison, psychic; all conditions
Smash	Reduce to 0 HP → shattered. Ends the snare **instantly for every creature in the mile**; **breaks the conduit and sends the emissary back into the seal**; **kills the ward.**
Restore	**Three arms** ☐☐☐
Shutter	With Tamsin's key and shutter-code: one action at the south wall. Ends the snare; **does not** slow or pause the Drawing. Manual lever — no toggling for time.
On any resolution	False sky clears to reveal the actual hour. Dawn does not occur early. Shutter stops the snare, not the ritual

Fire-Scribed Pedestal (objective — not a combatant)

AC	15
HP	**20** each (three: **N · E · W**)
Immunities	Fire, poison, psychic; all conditions
While burning	At least one burning pedestal is required for the Drawing to advance at all (with at least one captive bound). Each also grants Veyra one step of *Warded by the Ritual*. **No per-pedestal clock bonus.**
Destroyed	**−1 segment immediately** (min 0, **counted once per pedestal**), strips one ward benefit, and its fire gutters out (bright light in 10 ft. drops to dim). **Extinguishing every active pedestal stops the clock; it cannot un-crack a seal already breached.**

Iron Bracket and Bound Captive (objective — not a combatant)

Bracket	**AC 12, HP 10.** Four of them, set around the cradle ring.
Free a captive	One action at the bracket releases its visible safety catch, no roll. No check is needed to discover it. Alternatively destroy the bracket (AC 12, HP 10) or cast dispel magic on its 3rd-level binding. Each captive freed lowers the clock by 1 once (minimum 0). Unconscious captives must be carried using normal movement/carrying rules
The four	**Halen Croy** (bargeman's boy, twelve) · **Merra Voss** (pedlar) · **Bett Ralen** (fisher's widow) · **Andry Sull** (caravan guard). **Drained at segments 2 and 4 → unconscious and stable, not dead, reversible by restoring the alignment.** At segment 6 the seal cracks — a visible rescue window, survivable.
Freed captives	**Off the board:** they cannot be **killed remotely**, **re-taken by the ritual**, or targeted by Veyra's magic from across the room. They help only inside the party's own actions — **Halen** counts the stair's steps aloud and leads the freed down; **Merra** reads the maintenance marks and confirms which way an arm turns; **Bett** is a second pair of hands on the gimbal; **Andry** can name what burns in the floor. **No stat blocks, no invented powers.**
Every currently bound captive freed	The Drawing **stops dead** — with no captive bound the clock can no longer advance. Only the lens and the fiend remain. **Say so out loud.**

Encounter 2 — Tactical Layout *(written dimensions remain authoritative)*

Grid: 1 square = 5 ft. The chamber is a 60-ft circle. Compass: N up, S down.

The chamber floor. 60 ft. diameter, circular; stone, scored in concentric rings, wet in patches where the brine has been.

The central mechanism (dead centre). A **10-ft lens cradle** on a gimbal; the **Sarshel Glass** fills the middle 10 ft., 12 ft. tall. **Blocks line of sight across the centre — the fight naturally splits into west and east arcs.** Standing on the 2-ft plinth needs no climb.

Three fire-scribed pedestals at NORTH, EAST, and WEST — each **5 ft. wide, 4 ft. tall**, on the inner ring, **15 ft. from the cradle's rim** and **20 ft. from the centre. Half cover.**

Four iron captive brackets inside the cradle ring — at **NE, NW, SE, SW** of the cradle, roughly **8 ft. from the centre**, captives prone and facing the lens. **A bracket is inside Veyra's flanking distance and inside the fiend's reach from the centre.**

The stone stair, SOUTH — a **10-ft-wide opening in the south wall**, descending; **the party enters here**, and it is the only exit unless someone goes over the gallery.

The outer gallery — a **5-ft ring** inside the wall with a **3-ft parapet** and the brass dome 30 ft. overhead. **Going over the rail is a 90-ft fall to the silt** — which is why **Veyra takes the keeper's line** off the south-wall hoist-hooks. A PC who jumps without a safe descent method falls 90 ft.; genuine flight and climbing abilities work normally.; with the line, it is a controlled descent down the west wall using normal climbing movement.

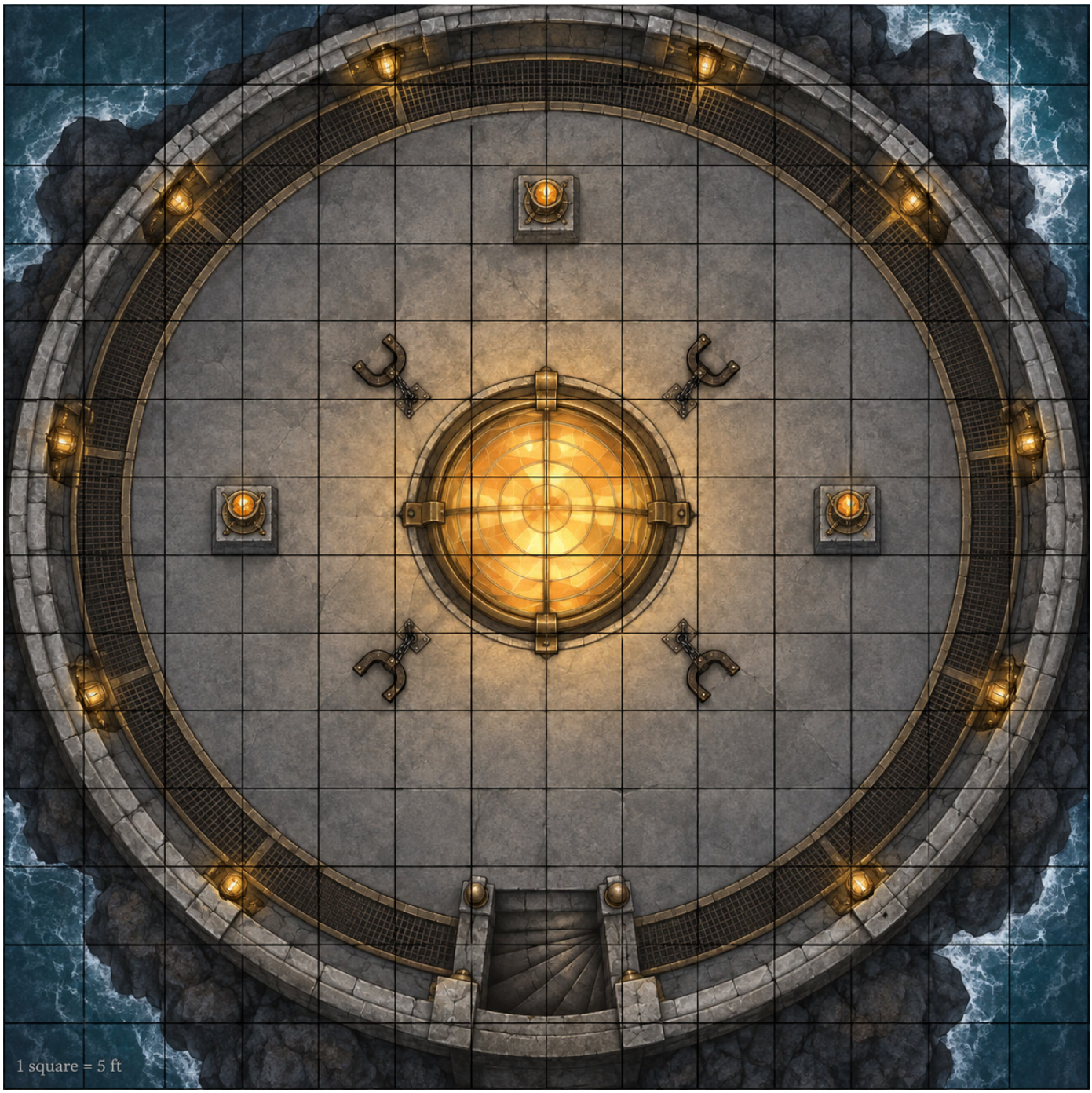
The keeper's gear, SOUTH WALL (west of the stair) — the shutter lever, the log-hooks, Tamsin's spare line and hoist-hooks. **The shutter is a one-action interact** ; recover the key and code from her belt.

Distances: stair mouth → cradle rim **25 ft.**; cradle rim → any pedestal **15 ft.**; centre → any pedestal **20 ft.**; wall to wall across the centre **60 ft.**; stair mouth → the far (north) wall **55 ft.** around the cradle — the "long way" is **75 ft.** and eats a Dash for most PCs.

Light: bright light in the **20-ft radius around the lens**, bright in **10 ft. around each burning pedestal**, dim to the walls; destroyed pedestals stop lighting. The night above is fixed and moonlit until the lens is resolved.

Hazards: from **segment 5**, a **10-ft fissure** runs from the cradle's south rim toward the stair — **difficult terrain**, **DEX DC 13** on entry or **2d6 acid** and **prone**.

Cover: lens cradle = full cover (blocks line of sight); pedestals = half cover; parapet = three-quarters if crouched on the gallery; stair mouth = full cover from the chamber's north half.


1 square = 5 ft

Player Handouts — The Lighthouse on Dry Land

Session 007 · The pictures below are the session's visual handouts. Show each one at the table as the party meets that thing — not all at once, and not before.

> ***Art generated:*** *show each illustration only when the party reaches its corresponding scene. Nothing on these pages tells the players where they are, who is waiting, or what the light is for — that is theirs to work out at the table.*
> ***Portrait pages are image and name only.*** *Each NPC/creature portrait page holds one picture scaled to fill the sheet and the name in large bold type at the foot of the page, added by the PDF renderer. The artwork carries no lettering of its own, and no captions or description bullets appear on those pages — show the picture and read the cues from File 1 aloud.*

Where We Left Off



Last session (006), confirmed: at the Green Lord's table, **Sela Wyndmere** read the ribbons she had carried blind for twelve years, named what they were, and **ripped the binding ribbon herself. Oberon burst into butterflies.** Something took the whole party by the middle of the chest and **threw them out of the Bright Court Beneath.** Sela's fate is unknown.

Tonight opens on the landing. You come down hard on a **night road over flat, cracked ground** — no wood, no court, no Sela, and no way to tell where the seam put you. The air is dry, the sea is nowhere, and low on the horizon, turning, is **a lighthouse.** It has no water to warn. It is the only light in the whole flat dark.

The Road and the Lighthouse



- A shoreline road with no shore: cracked blue-grey flats both ways, salt crust like broken crockery, oyster beds for miles.
- A chipped old **mile-stone** leans at your feet; its carved numeral is worn to a stub, and the chip looks **fresh**.
- The **sea is gone**; the road is not. No surf, anywhere.
- A **bell-buoy tolls** somewhere out on ground you could walk to.
- The **lighthouse turns, low and yellow-white** — a light with nothing to warn. Its beam sweeps the flats, and from the road you can watch it come round.

The Stranded Ship — the camp off the road



- A trader's hull lying on her beam ends out in the flat, high and dry and still standing — a little way off the road, roughly halfway between the road's edge and the light.
- **Masts as tent-poles**, tarpaulins strung between them, a **cook-fire** of scrap iron.
- A **row of salt-stained boots** nailed along the rail — one pair per traveller still living.
- Inside: people. Watchful, courteous, patient in a way that reads as waiting. They know the road loops. They know people have walked toward the light and not come back.



Tamsin Reed



Orin Vale



Veyra Sorn



Brine Fiend

Handout — Discovered

(Show only when the party actually finds this out — a PC reading the broken mile-stone's flank, the road signs, or the ledger.)

The milestone and the road. SAR–EL is still legible on the broken mile-stone. With it, an easy read (History or Survival DC 12) places the party: this is the coast road west of **New Sarshel**, in **Impiltur**, on ground that used to be underwater — and **New Sarshel is nine miles east**, well outside whatever has hold of this stretch of road.

DM Quick Reference — The Lighthouse on Dry Land

Session 007 · five Level 6 PCs · planned, not played.

Party and continuity

- Piper/Nalith, Lilli/Naan, Kaitlyn/Kto, Sev/Yinu arrive from Oberon's portal. Juniper's unnamed character is already on the road and witnesses the landing; build/resources follow the player's sheet.
- Tyvlex is off-camera; her location is a DM/player decision. Do not invent capture/death/separation complications. Sela, Oberon, Shadowdale, and other unresolved threads stay unresolved.
- The Fraternity did not create the portal. Local lighthouse material is **DM ADDITION**; Impiltur/New Sarshel/Fraternity foundation: CG p.145.

Act / Scene Flow

Scene	Purpose / immediate lead	Encounter	Table time
Act I, Scene 1.1 — Broken Milestone	Introduce Juniper immediately; compare contradictory visions. Five-minute road loop demonstrates trap. Orin answers with a lantern signal and warns four people were taken	None	10 min
Act I, Scene 1.2 — Stranded Camp	Names and stories make rescue personal. Orin gives dated warning, copied maintenance instructions, and torn ritual schedule; learn keeper is deceived, not cultist	None	25 min
Act II, Scene 2.1 — Dry Seabed	Reach tower, confront or bypass Tamsin, find restoration markings and keeper's key; upstairs sounds lead to captive rescue	Encounter 1, optional	20 min
Act II, Scene 2.2 — Lantern Chamber	Recognizable captives, marked alignment arms, and established deadline converge. Free people and choose how to end the conduit	Encounter 2	55 min
Aftermath	Actual sky returns; survivor aid and evidence offer voluntary leads into New Sarshel	None	10 min

- Camp bypassed: its warning is audible, tower has duplicate maintenance clues. Camp not mandatory.
- Boundary crossed: escape succeeds; no forced camp scene. Offer evacuation/rescue honestly.
- Ilde follows: warn party and let them intervene. Veyra needs a successful grapple and another binding action on a later turn; no free capture or clock bonus.

- Tamsin killed: alarm readies Veyra; clock begins at 1 rather than 0, once only. Key/code remain on her belt. Calmed/subdued: key and evidence recoverable without killing.

Geography and snare

- Sphere radius **one mile**, centered on lamp. Landing at west edge, camp halfway to tower and 400 ft off road; New Sarshel **nine miles east of tower**, outside sphere.
- Away from lamp on road: five-minute loop to milestone. Toward lamp: ordinary route. Off-road: ordinary travel, but visions/false sky remain until boundary. Camp inside radius; residents can evacuate, but many stayed for missing people or hoped-for visions.
- No compelled movement. Comparing different visions exposes the trick without a roll. Sleep/time work normally; camp supplies shelter, not exclusive permission to rest.
- **Magic (homebrew targets, normal spell limits):** dispel magic automatically ends one creature's 3rd-level personal glamour until new beam exposure; remove curse suppresses mark until dawn. Detect magic senses nearby magic, not a full map. Daylight illuminates; does not dispel. Actual flight/teleportation may cross boundary; fly can be available at Level 6.
- Shuttering, smashing, or restoring ends projected snare for everyone; only restoration preserves the ward.

Time — one deadline

- True dawn **three hours after landing**. Orin's hourglass and the ledger schedule establish it without a check. Walking to tower ~30 min plus chosen stops; one short rest costs one hour. Count fictional elapsed time, not discussion time.
- Arrival >1 hour before dawn: third pedestal inactive for encounter, fiend arrives round 2 and is half-manifested that round. Final hour: normal setup, fiend half-manifested round 1. Surprise uses ordinary stealth rules, not an automatic reward for avoiding rest.
- **Clock start:** Veyra starts at dawn or rushes the rite when confronted upstairs. Alarm readies her, does not start it. Start 0, or 1 for announced alarm (never stack). Unopposed at dawn: two advances per round, completion in three rounds. After that use breach aftermath, not a reset clock.
- Long rest misses dawn; warn before commitment. Short rest recovers only what actual character features allow. Depleted party: use lighter encounter option, not invented automatic slot recovery.

Encounter 1 — Tamsin (Act II, Scene 2.1)

- Optional, nonlethal; CR 5 **provisional**, 1,800 XP. AC16, HP85, bloodied42; +6 boat-hook, drag DC14, lamp flare DC14. Her homebrew restraint leaves a PC at1 HP/prone instead of0.
- Evidence/watch-words can end confrontation without roll; remove curse ends homebrew hold; dispel magic DC15; persuasive use of missing people's names DC13. Read stat card for details.
- Her standing order is guard exterior apron: she does not pursue past tideline or upstairs. Use normal movement/opportunity attacks to bypass, not disappearance.
- Keeper habits: checks wicks, insists on handrail, corrects nautical words. Once free, she explains the lamp and helps captives down stairs.

Encounter 2 — objectives (Act II, Scene 2.2)

- **Veyra:** AC16 HP90; fire-iron, Demon-Name recharge5–6, spell DC15. Choose ritual advance OR attack/spell action. Reaction Counter-Ward forces WIS DC15 when an arm is completed; failure resets that arm/progress. One reaction total; resolve before testing final alignment.
- **Ward benefits:** three active pedestals = radiant resistance and advantage on spell saves; two = radiant resistance only; one/zero = neither.
- **Fiend:** AC15 HP90; bite+two claws; recharge Drowning Grasp; no ritual action. Lesser emissary, not the larger sealed prisoner. Killing it alone does not stop ritual. Intact misaligned lens sustains it, not pedestal count.
- **Lens:** AC15 HP30, damage threshold10. Smash sends emissary back and destroys ward. Restore three arms: per arm one action +DC13 relevant check OR two actions no roll; progress persists. Failed checks add time; reactions may undo progress. No accelerated mending.
- **Shutter:** key plus written code, one action. Ends snare, NEVER pauses ritual. Key lootable regardless of Tamsin's fate.
- **Pedestals:** AC15 HP20 each; destroying active one reduces clock1, once. Third inactive in early encounter. No extra advancement per pedestal.
- **Captives:** release visible catch with one action, no roll, or destroy bracket AC12 HP10, or dispel its 3rd-level binding. Each rescued person reduces clock1 once. Carry unconscious people using normal movement. Freed people leave ritual targeting.
- **Veyra retreat:** below25 HP with fiend gone, tries gallery rope down west wall; use normal climbing movement and pursuit. Never automatic escape.

Drawing — authoritative rules

- End round +1 if at least one bound captive AND one burning pedestal. Veyra's action +1 under same conditions. **Maximum2 per round.** Fiend cannot advance.
- Captive freed or pedestal destroyed: –1, min0, once per target. Threshold events occur **once only** even on repeated crossings.
- No bound captive OR no burning pedestal stops counter; cannot restart with rescued captives. Stopping does not repair an already-cracked seal.

Segment	First-crossing event
1	Longing vision, no forced response
2	Halen unconscious/stable if still bound; if already freed, no effect
3	Fiend heals15 or gets advantage on its next attack; once only
4	Merra unconscious/stable if still bound; if already freed, no effect
5	Floor fissure: difficult terrain; entering it DEX13 or2d6 acid/prone
6	Seal cracks, no instant deaths. Three further rounds to restore and reseal; stair remains usable for rescue/retreat

- At6, smashing ends conduit but leaves cracked unwarded seal. After three-round recovery window, pressure stabilizes into a regional hazard; later lens resolution ends snare but cannot repair breach. No surprise explosion or additional automatic damage.
- Drained captives wake when lens is restored or smashed; otherwise remain stable, waking after an hour of care outside snare. Ordinary healing can wake them earlier. No automatic child death.

NPC cues and evidence custody

- **Orin:** courier, Tamsin's old friend; warm, mends boots, counts cups, ashamed of failed rescue. Holds her warning/copy, his tally, Andry's stolen schedule. Wants friends saved, fears harming Tamsin.
- **Ilde:** competent camp organizer grieving son; sees him alive in light. Comparing visions can persuade her without roll; useful evacuation leader, not a penalty trigger.
- **Veyra:** scholar seeking recognition; fears returning empty-handed. Straightens cuffs when threatened. Bargains for life, notes, lens, or time—not for already-rescued people to be returned. Deal terms depend on current board.
- **Captives:** Halen counts steps/knots; Merra knows trade contacts; Bett mends nets and helps carry; Andry escaped briefly with schedule then recaptured. Their help is practical, not extra combat turns.
- Count: 15 travelers excluding Orin =9 camp+4 captive+2 earlier exposure deaths. Camp has10 living including Orin. Juniper/PCs not included in old tally.
- Original keeper log in tower; Orin has copy. Veyra's full ledger contains city addresses, not the torn schedule. Leads depend on what party actually acquires.

Outcomes / post-play notes

- Restore before or during recovery window: seal repaired, ward preserved, fiend banished without tooth. Survivors may keep waystation.
- Smash before6: seal intact but unwarded. After6: cracked and unwarded. Fiend returns, tooth if collected; evacuate or investigate later.
- Shutter only: snare ends, rite continues. Clock stopped by rescue/pedestals alone: seal safe if before6, but snare/lens still need resolution or the party can leave the area.
- Killing fiend or smashing lens leaves tooth; restoration does not. Veyra has15 gp; clothing is ordinary, resistances not transferable.
- Sky reveals actual time, not instant sunrise. Merra can offer introductions; no predetermined hostile reception in New Sarshel.
- Record actual survivors, Ilde's choice, Tamsin's state, Veyra's fate, ledger custody, ward/seal state, Juniper's chosen identity. Keep session-log unchanged until play; no predetermined level-up.